



Rebel route: Salgaocar FC's (left) decline began in 2016 when it pulled out of the I-League after objecting to the AIFF's restructuring decisions regarding the I-League and ISL. PTI

Atletico de Kolkata, West Bengal ISL | Disbanded in 2020

Initially named Atletico de Kolkata due to its affiliation with Spanish club Atletico de Madrid, the Kolkata-based football club, later known simply as ATK, competed in the Indian Super League (ISL) from its inaugural campaign until the 2019–20 season. ATK clinched the ISL Cup three times: in 2014, 2016, and the 2019–20 season, the last of which came when the ISL was recognised as India's top-tier league.

During the closing months of that season, ATK's owners, the RPSG Group, along with Sourav Ganguly and entrepreneur Utsav Parekh, bought a majority stake in I-League side Mohun Bagan. In July 2020, ATK was officially disbanded, paving the way for Mohun Bagan to join the ISL as ATK Mohun Bagan in the 2020–21 season.

United Sikkim FC, Sikkim I-League | Disbanded in 2021

United Sikkim FC, co-owned by former Indian men's team captain Bhaichung Bhutia, was founded in 2011. Nicknamed the 'Snow Lions', it is the only club from Sikkim to have played in the I-League. It competed

in the Sikkim Premier Division League and played home matches at the Paljor Stadium. In September 2019, Bhutia announced the club was shutting down due to unavoidable circumstances. It was briefly revived in January 2021 before being permanently closed down, even though its academy still exists.

Indian Arrows, AIFF I-League | Disbanded in 2022

Indian Arrows FC was established in 2010 by the AIFF as a developmental team, initially known as AIFF XI, to nurture young Indian football talent. After a brief disbandment in 2013 due to financial constraints, it was revived in 2017. The club provided a platform for India's brightest youth players to gain I-League experience, aiming to strengthen the national team.

Chennai City FC, Tamil Nadu I-League | Disbanded in 2023

Nicknamed 'The Lions', Chennai City FC was founded in 1946 as Nethaji Sports Club. It primarily competed in state leagues for decades before being renamed in 2014. The club gained national prominence when it entered the I-League in 2016, achieving its

INSTITUTIONAL SIDES

In the past, the top tier of Indian football (I-League, previously NFL) had many institutional sides.

These teams rarely challenged for the title but were strong enough to do well in the second division and earn promotion. The teams included Hindustan Aeronautics Sports Club (commonly known as HAL SC), Oil and Natural Gas Corporation Football Club (ONGC FC), and State Bank of Travancore Football Club (SBT FC). These three, along with the omnipresent Air India FC, which won the Durand Cup in 2012, were the crème de la crème among 'office' teams. In 2010, following the disbanding of clubs associated with public sector undertakings for not fulfilling Asian Football Confederation (AFC) club licensing criteria, the AIFF was planning to create a league for corporate clubs. It held a preliminary meeting with 25 interested teams on 31 August 2023; however, the league is yet to materialise.

greatest success by winning the title in the 2018–19 season. However, due to persistent failures in complying with AIFF's club licensing regulations, it was barred from the 2021–22 I-League. On March 3, 2023, the club officially transferred its sporting licence, signalling its exit from professional football and effectively disbanding its senior team.

Salgaocar FC, Goa NFL, I-League | Disbanded in 2023

Salgaocar FC, based in Goa, was one of the most successful clubs in the country. After its formation in 1956, the team won numerous major trophies, including the NFL in the 1998–99 season and the I-League in 2010–11. Additionally, the club also won four Federation Cups, three Durand Cups, three Rovers Cups and two Indian Super Cups. The team's decline began in 2016 when it pulled out of the I-League after objecting to the AIFF's restructuring decisions regarding the I-League and ISL. In 2023, the club announced it was shutting down senior team operations.